

A decorative background in the top right corner consisting of numerous triangles in shades of pink, teal, and white, arranged in a pattern that suggests a stylized sunburst or a cluster of data points.

User Guide

Looked After Children Longitudinal Dataset – Scotland

Owner: The Scottish Government

Date: March 2026

Version: 1.0



Version Control

Date of update:	Type of update:	Corresponding version:	Author:

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Glossary

CSO	Compulsory Supervision Order; a legal measure made by the Children's Hearings System in Scotland, setting out the compulsory conditions under which a child must be cared for or supervised.
Data Quality Flag	Indicators added to the dataset to highlight issues such as missing dates, overlapping placements or inconsistencies.
Destination	at Episode End; the type of accommodation or arrangement a child moves to once a care episode ends.
Episode	A period of time in which a child is continuously in care of the local authority. An episode is composed of placements and can contain more than one placement of different types. The end of an episode is when the child is no longer in care, and the destination accommodation should be filled out.
GIRFEC	Getting It Right for Every Child; Scotland's national framework for supporting children, young people and families.
Indexing	or Spine Indexing; the process of matching dataset records to the NRS population spine using demographic identifiers.
Legal reason	The legal reason which shows compliance with the law for a child to be looked after by the local authority (e.g. Accommodated under section 25).
NRS Spine	Population Spine; a national index maintained by National Records Scotland used to enable secure and consistent linkage across datasets.
Placement	A period of time in which a child is in care of the local authority, the specific type of care (e.g. with prospective adopters) is recorded. Multiple placements can form a continuous episode of care.

PO	Permanence Order; granted by a court (not by the Children's Hearing), providing longer-term security and stability for a child who cannot return home. A child on a Permanence Order is still legally "looked after".
POA	Permanence Order with Authority to Adopt; a specific type of Permanence Order that gives the local authority permission to place a child for adoption.
Pupil Census	Annual collection of individual-level data on pupils in Scotland.
SCN	Scottish Candidate Number
ScotXed	Scottish Exchange of Data; the Scottish Government unit responsible for collecting and validating education and children's social work data from local authorities.
TRE	Trusted Research Environment; a secure computing environment where de-identified data are accessed for research, typically without physical data extraction.
UNCRC	United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child

1. Introduction and Context

Purpose

This User Guide is primarily designed to support accredited researchers, analysts and other data users who are considering using this dataset for public good research. It provides essential information about the dataset, including its structure, scope and research potential, to help users develop robust and feasible research applications.

This guide is intended to be used alongside the corresponding Data Dictionary, which details the variables and technical specifications of the dataset. Together, these documents aim to ensure transparency, usability and accessibility of the data.

Dataset Overview

The **Looked After Children Longitudinal Dataset – Scotland** brings together annual returns of children who were looked after by local authorities in Scotland. It contains information on:

- Characteristics of children in care
- Episodes of care (continuous periods during which a child was legally looked after)
- Placements within episodes
- Legal reasons for being looked after

The dataset currently includes data from **2008/09 to 2023/24**, covering approximately:

- 72,000 children
- 85,000 episodes
- 179,000 placements
- 248,000 recorded legal reasons.

Motivation for Linkage

Linking Looked After Children data across years to other administrative sources provides a powerful foundation for understanding children's experiences before, during and after

periods of care. Longitudinal linkage enables detailed analysis of care journeys over time, including pathways into and out of care, placement stability and the factors associated with re-entry. By linking the data to education, health and justice datasets, researchers can examine outcomes beyond the care system and build a fuller picture of children's life-course trajectories. These capabilities also support the Scottish Government's commitments under [The Promise](#), [GIRFEC](#) and the [UNCRC Incorporation Programme](#), all of which emphasise prevention, early intervention, children's rights and improved outcomes for care-experienced young people.

The dataset has been designed to be linkable to other administrative datasets through established Scottish linkage infrastructure.

Further details are provided in Section 4.

Research Potential and Policy Relevance

The **Looked After Children Longitudinal Dataset – Scotland** provides a powerful linked resource for analysing children's care journeys, placement stability, legal routes into care and outcomes, with the potential to be linked to education, health, census and other administrative data sources for approved research. It supports several major Scottish Government priorities, including [The Promise](#), [GIRFEC](#), [Additional Support for Learning](#), [Care Leavers and Aftercare](#) and the [National Performance Framework](#). It can also inform future policy development, including work related to the [Children \(Care, Care Experience and Services Planning\) \(Scotland\) Bill](#) currently progressing through the Scottish Parliament.

In addition, the dataset contributes to the wider work of the [Promise Data and Evidence Group](#), helping address longstanding evidence gaps around children's experiences, wellbeing and long-term outcomes for care-experienced people.

Further details are provided in Section 5.

Comparable Datasets

There are several UK and international datasets that provide information on children's social care needs, care experience and outcomes and, therefore, offer useful points of comparison

with the **Looked After Children Longitudinal Dataset – Scotland**. These sources vary in scope and design, but many contain broadly similar information on children receiving statutory support, placement types, care pathways and outcomes. Together, they can help researchers understand differences in policy, practice and population needs across jurisdictions, support cross-national comparisons and provide supplementary context when interpreting Scottish findings. They also offer opportunities for multi-dataset studies, enabling researchers to explore how care systems operate across different legislative and organisational structures.

Further details on these datasets are available through the links below.

- **Children in Need (CiN) Census (England):** <https://www.gov.uk/guidance/children-in-need-census>
- **SSDA903 Looked After Children Dataset (England):** <https://www.gov.uk/government/collections/statistics-looked-after-children>
- **Growing Up in England (GUIE) – Wave 2: Children in Need / Children Looked After:** <https://www.ons.gov.uk/peoplepopulationandcommunity/educationandchildcare/methodologies/growingupinenglandguie>
- **Children Receiving Care and Support Census (Wales):** <https://www.adruk.org/data-access/flagship-datasets/children-receiving-care-and-support-census/>
- **Children in Need Census – Wales (CINW):** <https://statswales.gov.wales>
- **Looked After Children Dataset – Wales:** <https://www.adruk.org/data-access/flagship-datasets/looked-after-children-wales/>
- **Children in Care – Northern Ireland:** <https://www.health-ni.gov.uk/publications/childrens-social-care-statistics-northern-ireland-202425>
- **International equivalents (e.g., Nordic care-experience datasets):** National data agencies in Sweden, Norway, Denmark and Finland produce robust administrative datasets on children in alternative care, suitable for cross-national comparison.

2. About the Data

Data Owner

Scottish Ministers

Contact Details

For any questions or queries on the dataset, please contact:

The Scottish Government

Children and Families Analysis

Education Analytical Services

childrens.statistics@gov.scot

Data Collection Details

This dataset has been constructed by combining annual returns from Scottish local authorities' social work information systems. The processing aims to create a set of non-overlapping episodes of care for a child, with details of care placements and the associated legal reasons. The processing also identifies where there may be data issues arising from changes between annual returns, as well as missing data. In some cases, these issues are resolved during processing, while in others the potentially inconsistent records are retained and the issue is flagged.

Full details of the processing undertaken, and its implications for use of the data, can be found in the [Looked After Children Longitudinal Data Technical Report](#).

The input data for this flagship dataset are annual returns submitted by local authorities to the Scottish Government via the [Scottish Exchange of Data \(ScotXed\)](#).

Data are derived from Scottish local authority management information systems and include four file types:

1. **Child file** – demographic and identifying information
2. **Episode file** – episodes of care and related variables
3. **Placement file** – placements within each episode
4. **Legal reason file** – legal basis for the child being looked after

The annual datasets include all children looked after at any point between **1 August and 31 July** of each reporting year. This includes:

- Children looked after at home and away from home
- Data from all local authorities in Scotland
- Full histories of any episodes of care in place during the reporting year, with associated placements and legal reasons.

The Scottish Government Children and Families Analysis team applies validation checks before the dataset is finalised for official statistics.

Latest Release Date

The **Looked After Children Longitudinal Dataset – Scotland**, created from these annual returns, was last released in November 2021. The second release of this dataset is due in autumn 2026.

The dataset is expected to be updated within the Scottish National Safe Haven every two years.

Data Scope and Coverage

The children included in the longitudinal dataset are children who are in the care of a local authority under the **Children (Scotland) Act 1995**, otherwise known as *looked after children*.

The dataset comprises annual returns submitted by local authorities to the Scottish Government and covers the period **from 1 April 2008 to 31 July 2024**. Some historic records prior to 1 April 2008 are included where a child was already in care before this date and continued to be looked after during the period covered by the collection.

The data are held in two tables:

1. **Placement dataset:** One record per care placement per child, containing child characteristics, dates and details of care episodes, and dates and details of care placements.
2. **Legal reasons dataset:** One record per legal reason per child, including child characteristics, dates and details of the legal reasons for the child being looked after.

Child characteristics included in these datasets reflect the most recent information available for the child.

Time Period Covered

2008/09 to 2023/24

Geographical Coverage

- All 32 Scottish local authorities
- No regions excluded.

3. Data Quality

Understanding the quality of this dataset is essential for conducting robust and reliable analysis. This section outlines how the data is processed, linked and de-identified, and provides information on its comparability across years and regions. It highlights the strengths and known limitations of the dataset, including any issues with completeness, consistency or changes in methodology. By reviewing this section, you will gain insight into the reliability of the data and how best to interpret it in your research.

Data Processing

The **Looked After Children Longitudinal Dataset – Scotland** is created by bringing together annual returns from local authorities and applying a series of processing steps to produce a consistent, linkable dataset suitable for longitudinal analysis. These steps address changes across years, variations in local authority systems and common data quality issues.

Key processing steps include:

- Combining yearly files for each file type
- Creating a **Corrected Unique ID** to resolve identifier changes over time
- Removing duplicate records
- Retaining the most recent values when inconsistencies occur (e.g., date of birth)
- Recoding invalid values (e.g., missing leading zeros, unrecognised category codes)
- Constructing child-level and record-level data quality flags.

The input data include a unique child identifier (the **social work identifier**), which is generated within local authority management information systems and is unique to each local authority. This identifier is used to link records within and across annual returns to build a longitudinal history for each child.

Where a child has attended a publicly funded school in Scotland, a **Scottish Candidate Number (SCN)** may also be present. The longitudinal linkage is strengthened by combining

records for children that share the same SCN, gender, and month and year of birth. This approach helps resolve cases where a child moves between local authorities, or where local authority system upgrades result in identifier changes. When such changes are identified, the processing stage creates a unified **Corrected Unique ID** to maintain continuity over time. No direct identifiers are included in the research dataset.

Linkage to other datasets is achieved via the **NRS spine**. Spine matching is achieved using postcode, gender and date of birth of the individuals. **Further detail is provided in Section 4.**

Data Comparability

The data are broadly comparable over time. This dataset will produce results that are largely consistent with those published in the [Scottish Government's Children's Social Work Statistics](#). However, outputs may not be identical because additional processing has been undertaken to create the longitudinal dataset from the annual returns.

Further information on data quality, methodology and historical revisions to the official National Statistics series is available in the most recent publication and accompanying guidance, which can be found at: <https://www.gov.scot/collections/childrens-social-work/>

Data Quality Flags

Data quality reflects the underlying administrative records, and most values are retained as originally submitted by local authorities, including any recording errors. A comprehensive set of data-quality flags is included in the longitudinal dataset to highlight issues identified during processing, such as:

- Missing or inconsistent dates
- Missing Scottish Candidate Numbers (SCNs) or changes in SCN over time
- Overlapping placements
- Duplicate episodes
- Changes or inconsistencies in demographic identifiers.

These flags enable users to identify records that may be outdated, inconsistent or require additional caution when interpreting.

Synthetic Data Availability

Synthetic data is not available for this dataset.

Document Links

- **Metadata Record:** <https://www.researchdata.scot/metadata-catalogue/search-results/result/?id=437&originId=0>
- **Data Dictionary:** Available upon request.
- **Technical Guide:** <https://www.scadr.ac.uk/sites/default/files/Technical%20Guide%20-%20Looked%20After%20Children%20Longitudinal%20Dataset%20-%20Scotland%20-%202022.pdf>

Providing Feedback on the Data

Researchers are encouraged to report issues, inconsistencies or suggestions for improvement.

For any feedback on the dataset, please contact:

The Scottish Government

Children and Families Analysis

Education Analytical Services

childrens.statistics@gov.scot

Community Groups

There is currently no formal user group dedicated specifically to the **Looked After Children Longitudinal Dataset – Scotland**. However, ADR Scotland plans to establish a regular user forum and online community as the number of researchers working with the data grows. These groups will provide opportunities for discussion, peer learning and the sharing of analytical methods or findings. To register your interest in joining these activities, please contact: ADRScotland@gov.scot.

Users may find value in connecting with the [Promise Data and Evidence Group \(DEG\)](#). Established in 2025 and chaired by the Scottish Government's Chief Social Policy Adviser, the DEG brings together analysts from across Scotland to strengthen the data and evidence available to understand progress towards keeping *The Promise*. The Group publishes a workplan and a series of evidence reviews—including recent longitudinal analyses of health and wellbeing of care experienced children and young people—which may be useful for researchers working with this dataset.

In addition, the [Children's Care and Protection Data Community for Scotland \(Knowledge Hub\)](#) provides updates, guidance and information on relevant events and resources across the children's social care analytical community. It is open to analysts, practitioners and researchers interested in children's care and protection data.

4. Data Linkage Methodology

Linkage Overview

The **Looked After Children Longitudinal Dataset – Scotland** is designed to support linkage to other administrative datasets through established Scottish linkage services. Linkage enables researchers to follow children's outcomes across education, health and other available domains, and is supported by secure indexing and matching processes delivered by accredited national services. Further technical detail on linkage pathways is provided below.

Legal and Governance

The legal basis for local authorities supplying these data to the Scottish Government is set out in **Section 199 of the Local Government (Scotland) Act 1973**, which makes provision for every local authority to provide any information to the Scottish Minister, via the Scottish Government, that may be required. **Section 8 of the Social Work (Scotland) Act 1968** provides the legislation to collect data about children and young people within scope of Children's Social Work Statistics data collections.

All linkage activity is governed by established Scottish Government data governance processes and trusted access arrangements through ADR Scotland. Linkage, indexing and matching are conducted only within accredited environments and in accordance with national information-governance standards. Access to linked data for research purposes is provided exclusively through secure **Trusted Research Environments (TREs)**, ensuring that personal identifiers are protected and that only de-identified, linkable data are available to researchers.

Linkage Provider and Spine

Indexing and matching for this dataset are carried out by the **National Records of Scotland (NRS) Indexing Service**, using established linkage methodologies. The population spine

enables consistent cross-sector linkage that is then facilitated through pseudonymised identifiers.

The linkage process relies on the matching of Pupil Census information via date of birth, postcode, and gender. For individuals in the LAC dataset that have a Scottish Candidate Number (SCN) matches to the spine are assigned from those identified in Pupil Census. For children who do not yet have an SCN – mostly commonly younger children – date of birth, postcode, and gender will be used to identify extra spine matches using similar methodology as Pupil Census. This enhances linkage coverage and allows records to be associated with the correct population-spine identifier.

No direct identifiers are included in the research dataset.

Linkage Quality and Limitations

This section will be completed once the autumn 2026 linkage has been done by NRS. A detailed linkage report will be available via the metadata record for this dataset. A linkage report for iteration 1 of this data can be requested in the meantime via:

ADRScotland@gov.scot

5. Research Potential

Looked after children have been, and remain, a central focus of Scottish Government policy, particularly following [The Promise](#) (2020), which emerged from Scotland's Independent Care Review and set out a long-term vision for a care system in which all children grow up “*loved, safe and respected so that they realise their full potential*”. The Promise, and the subsequent programme **Keeping the Promise** (from 2022 onwards), commit Scotland to reshaping support around families, preventing unnecessary separation, improving placement stability and ensuring sustained, lifelong support for care-experienced people. Together, these commitments aim to transform Scotland's care system by 2030, embedding early help, whole-family approaches, children's rights and sustained wellbeing across practice and service design.

The Promise and its subsequent assessments have also highlighted persistent gaps in the data and evidence needed to understand inequalities and improve outcomes for care-experienced people. These include gaps relating to health and mental health outcomes and access, sibling relationships and separation, and the long term trajectories of care-experienced adults across education, employment, housing, justice and health. The [Promise Story of Progress](#) and the development of the [Promise Progress Framework](#) have further emphasised the need for consistent, high quality, linkable data to understand children's and families' experiences and monitor national progress.

This work is closely connected to the [Promise Data and Evidence Group \(DEG\)](#), established in 2025 and chaired by the Scottish Government's Chief Social Policy Adviser, Professor Linda Bauld. The Group brings together analysts from across Scotland to identify data gaps, strengthen Scotland's evidence infrastructure and support research that advances understanding of progress towards keeping The Promise. The Group's publications – such as the [Longitudinal quantitative evidence review for Keeping The Promise: health and wellbeing of care experienced children and young people \(2025\)](#) – reinforce the importance of robust, linkable administrative data for monitoring health, wellbeing, education and longer term adult outcomes for care-experienced people. The **Looked After Children Longitudinal Dataset – Scotland** directly contributes to addressing many of these evidence needs. There

are plans to publish an Areas of Research Interest on The Promise by autumn 2026 - researchers seeking this and any other relevant up-to-date analytical priorities can refer to the Scottish Government's [Areas of Research Interest](#).

In addition to the Promise, the dataset aligns with wider Scottish Government priorities to eradicate child poverty, improve outcomes for children and young people and deliver Scotland's National Outcomes, particularly those relating to children, communities and wellbeing.

Within ADR Scotland, the dataset sits primarily within the Children & Young People Strategic Research Theme, while also offering strong cross-over with the Health, Mental Health & Social Care theme given its relevance to early intervention, wellbeing, care stability and long-term outcomes across the life course.

What Research is Possible

This dataset provides a rich longitudinal resource for understanding the experiences and outcomes of looked after children in Scotland. It supports detailed tracking of children's care journeys over time, including episodes, transitions, placement stability and legal routes into care such as Compulsory Supervision Orders (CSOs), Permanence Orders (POs) and Permanence Orders with Authority to Adopt (POAs). Researchers can analyse variation across local authorities and demographic groups and examine the timing, duration and sequencing of care episodes.

By linking to education, health, housing and other ADR Scotland datasets, the dataset also enables analysis of children's outcomes before, during and after care. This includes research relevant to The Promise, GIRFEC, child poverty reduction, additional support needs and whole-family support approaches. It can also contribute to future Scottish Government Areas of Research Interest (ARIs), including those planned around The Promise (focused on care-experienced young people). The dataset further supports analysis of long-term adult outcomes, helping to understand how early care experiences shape wellbeing, participation and life chances in later life.

Example Research Questions

Below are illustrative research questions of how the dataset could be used, with some requiring linkage to other datasets.

Care journeys, stability and legal processes:

- How do placement stability, placement breakdown and the duration and sequencing of care episodes differ across local authorities and demographic groups, and what factors predict re-entry into care?
- What factors predict re-entry into care?

Transitions, wellbeing and family context:

- How do children's mental health and wellbeing trajectories evolve before, during and after periods of being looked after?
- How do sibling relationships and family level factors shape these transitions?

Education, attainment and engagement:

- How does being looked after influence school engagement, attendance, attainment and post 16 destinations?
- To what extent does the timing of entry into care shape later educational pathways?

Poverty, inequality and local context:

- How do neighbourhood deprivation, financial instability and household income shocks relate to patterns of care involvement and placement availability across Scotland?

Long-term and cross-sector outcomes:

- What long term adult outcomes—across health, employment, justice involvement and housing—are associated with different early care experiences (e.g., kinship, residential, foster care)?
- What protective factors contribute to resilience and positive later-life trajectories?

Previous Use Cases

This dataset has already supported several important pieces of research using Scottish administrative data on looked after children. Analyses of earlier iterations of the dataset demonstrate the value of linked administrative records for understanding early intervention, care journeys and long-term outcomes. These include:

- Soraghan, J. & Porter, R. (2024). [Growing Up in Kinship Care](#). October 2024.
- Soraghan, J., Raab, G., Troncoso, P., Treanor, M. & Porter, R. (2023). [The Impact of COVID-19 on Children's Care Journeys in Scotland: An Analysis of the Administrative Data on 'Looked After' Children](#).
- Raab, G., Soraghan, J., Macintyre, C., McGhee, J. & Troncoso, P. (2023). [Infants born into care in Scotland: Updated report: including data to July 2021](#).
- Raab, G., Macintyre, C., & McGhee, J. (2020). [Infants born into care in Scotland: Initial findings](#).

These studies illustrate the strength of Scotland's administrative data in providing insight into care experiences, inequalities and outcomes for children and families. Building on this foundation, the **Looked After Children Longitudinal Dataset – Scotland** will continue to enable robust, longitudinal and cross-sector research to inform policy and practice across Scotland.

6. Accessing the Data

How to Access the Data

Access to this dataset is available to accredited researchers within the Scottish **National Safe Haven**, a secure Trusted Research Environment (TRE). Access is requested through the Scottish Government & National Records of Scotland (SG & NRS) Data Access Panel, which oversees approval for this dataset.

Researchers should begin by submitting an application using the form provided on the Scottish Government website: <https://www.gov.scot/publications/scottish-government-statistics-request-our-data/>

In addition, researchers can find introductory guidance on accessing secure datasets and general information on approval pathways through Research Data Scotland (RDS):

<https://www.researchdata.scot/accessing-data/data-access-overview/>

RDS can provide initial support and guide you to the right resources via their initial enquiry form: <https://www.researchdata.scot/accessing-data/begin-an-enquiry/>

All data must be analysed within the National Safe Haven, where outputs can only be exported following disclosure control checks.

Application and Approvals

The **Looked After Children Longitudinal Dataset – Scotland** is accessed through the SG & NRS Data Access Panel (previously the Statistics Public Benefit and Privacy Panel). This approvals route ensure that access is lawful, ethical and aligned with the public good.

The application form and guidance are available here:

<https://www.gov.scot/publications/scottish-government-statistics-request-our-data/>

A typical application process involves:

1. Developing a research proposal, including project purpose and public benefit.
2. Submitting an application to the SG & NRS Data Access Panel for review.
3. Obtaining approvals, including information governance checks, panel approval, confirmation from relevant data controllers, and – where required – ethical approval.
4. Completing required training, such as Safe Researcher Training.
5. Accessing the dataset within the secure Trusted Research Environment.

Researchers may also consult RDS resources for additional support on preparing an enquiry or understanding approval pathways: <https://www.researchdata.scot/accessing-data/researcher-access-service/pbpp-approval-pathway/>

Output Clearance and Acknowledgements

All research outputs must undergo statistical **disclosure control** before they can be released from the National Safe Haven. This review is carried out by Safe Haven staff trained in disclosure-control methods to ensure that no confidential or potentially disclosive information is included in results.

Required acknowledgements or citation formats will be provided in the project documentation issued during approval.

Support and Contact Information

For queries relating to the SG & NRS Data Access Panel or to submit an application: SPBPP@gov.scot

For general guidance on accessing secure datasets for research, or to submit an initial enquiry through Research Data Scotland, please visit:

<https://www.researchdata.scot/accessing-data/researcher-access-service/pbpp-approval-pathway/>

7. Appendix

Supporting Documentation and Metadata

- **Metadata Catalogue Entry:** Metadata record including description, structure, access routes and downloadable supporting files. <https://www.researchdata.scot/metadata-catalogue/search-results/result/?id=437&originId=0>
- **Technical Report:**
<https://www.scadr.ac.uk/sites/default/files/Technical%20Guide%20-%20Looked%20After%20Children%20Longitudinal%20Dataset%20-%20Scotland%20-%202022.pdf>
- **Data Explained (2023):** Summarises dataset structure, variables, known issues and access processes.
<https://www.scadr.ac.uk/sites/default/files/Data%20Explained%20Scottish%20Government%20Looked%20After%20Children%20Longitudinal%20Dataset%20April%202023FINAL.pdf>
- **Metadata Files (XLSX):** Available via the RDS metadata record (under “Associated media”). <https://www.researchdata.scot/metadata-catalogue/search-results/result/?id=437&originId=0>
- **Annual Collection Documentation (ScotXed):** Survey guidance, templates and data specifications for Looked After Children and Care Leavers.
<https://www.gov.scot/publications/scottish-exchange-of-data-looked-after-children/>

Research Outputs and Insights

Published Research

- **Infants Born Into Care in Scotland (2020, 2023):** <https://www.adruk.org/news-publications/publications-reports/infants-born-into-care-in-scotland/>

- **Impact of COVID-19 on Children's Care Journeys (2023):** <https://publichealthscotland.scot/repository/the-impact-of-covid-19-on-children-s-care-journeys-in-scotland/>
- **Growing Up in Kinship Care (2024):** <https://www.adruk.org/news-publications/publications-reports/growing-up-in-kinship-care/>

Additional Research & Insight Resources

- **ADR UK – Looked After Children Longitudinal Dataset (Resource Library):** Includes research highlights and examples. <https://www.adruk.org/data-access/flagship-datasets/looked-after-children-longitudinal-dataset/>
- **Linking Administrative Datasets About Looked After Children (Policy Briefing):** University of Stirling policy briefing on linking Children Looked After Statistics (CLAS) and Scottish Children's Reporter Administration (SCRA) data. <https://www.stir.ac.uk/media/stirling/services/research/documents/policy-briefings/Linking-administrative-datasets-about-looked-after-children.pdf>

Official Statistics

- **Children's Social Work Statistics: Looked After Children:** Annual statistical publications. <https://www.gov.scot/collections/childrens-social-work/>

Code and Technical Resources

At present, no publicly shared code repositories specific to this dataset are available.

However, the following resources provide technical guidance:

- **Data Explained (2023):** Includes practical examples of working with variables, data quality, and linkage processes. https://www.scadr.ac.uk/sites/default/files/Data%20Explained_Scottish%20Government_Looked%20After%20Children%20Longitudinal%20Dataset_April%202023FINAL.pdf
- **Webinar recording and technical overview:** Available via ADR UK under "Other supporting resources" <https://www.adruk.org/data-access/flagship-datasets/looked-after-children-longitudinal-dataset/>

About ADR Scotland

ADR Scotland is transforming how public sector data in Scotland is curated, accessed and explored, so it can deliver its full potential for policymakers and the public. Combining specialists in the Scottish Government with the Scottish Centre for Administrative Data Research (SCADR), together they are making administrative datasets more readily linkable and conducting public good research safely and securely on a suite of critical issues in Scotland.

www.adrscotland.org

